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ABSTRACT
Cybersecurity is becoming an essential part of modern life, especially for students who rely heavily on the internet for studies, entertainment, communication, and financial activities. With increasing online usage, students face many digital risks such as hacking, phishing, identity theft, malware, and data leaks. This study aims to understand the level of cybersecurity awareness among undergraduate and postgraduate students in the Varale area. The research was conducted among 159 students from different streams.
Findings show that although students claim to know about cybersecurity, many of them still follow unsafe online habits. Weak passwords, clicking unknown links, ignoring software updates, and oversharing information on social media are common behaviors. A large number of students reported experiencing or witnessing cyberattacks, showing that cyber risks are real and growing.
This research highlights the need for regular and practical cybersecurity training in colleges. Students must learn safe digital habits through hands-on activities, workshops, and awareness programs. The study concludes that cybersecurity education should become a compulsory part of the curriculum to protect students from increasing online threats.

INTRODUCTION
Technology has become an inseparable part of every student's life. Students use smartphones, laptops, and the internet daily for assignments, online classes, chatting, online banking, cloud storage, and entertainment. Although technology has made life easier, it has also increased the chances of cyberattacks. Students often become victims of phishing, identity theft, fake websites, and scams because they are unaware of proper cybersecurity practices.
Many students mistakenly believe that cyberattacks only happen to big companies or famous people, but in reality, students are common targets because they use simple passwords, click on unknown links, or download unsafe apps. Even when students know about cybersecurity, they do not always follow safe habits. This mismatch between what students know and how they actually behave online is called a gap between knowledge and practice.
This research focuses on students of the Varale area and tries to understand their awareness level, online habits, experiences with cyber threats, and need for training. The study helps colleges understand how to

improve cybersecurity education and protect students in the digital age.

OBJECTIVES

- To study the current level of cybersecurity awareness among undergraduate and postgraduate students.
- To identify the types of cyber threats faced by students in everyday digital activities.
- To examine the connection between students' online habits and their actual cybersecurity behavior.
- To provide practical suggestions for improving cybersecurity awareness among students.
- To highlight the need for regular training and cybersecurity programs in colleges.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Kumar and Raj (2020) examined the cybersecurity awareness levels of university students and found that although most students understood basic cyber threats, they often failed to apply this knowledge in real situations. Their study highlighted that students tend to use weak passwords, reuse the same credentials, or ignore software updates, making them vulnerable to attacks. The findings emphasized that theoretical awareness alone is not enough unless supported by safe online behavior. [1]

Likewise, Meena and Singh (2021) analyzed cybersecurity habits among undergraduate students and concluded that a majority of students fall for phishing emails because they are unable to identify suspicious links or fraudulent messages. Their study also noted that students underestimate the seriousness of cyber threats, believing that attacks will not happen to them. This mindset increases their chances of being targeted by cybercriminals. [2]

In a study by Joseph and Mathew (2022), researchers explored the difference in cybersecurity awareness between undergraduate and postgraduate students. They found that postgraduate students generally have higher theoretical knowledge, but both groups share similar unsafe digital habits. The study concluded that a significant knowledge–behavior gap exists among students, regardless of their academic level. This gap leads to careless actions such as clicking unknown links, oversharing on social media, and ignoring warnings. [3]

Moreover, Kaur and Sharma (2023) investigated the effectiveness of cybersecurity training programs in colleges. Their study revealed that while many colleges conduct awareness sessions, the training is often lecture-based and does not include practical exercises. Students reported that they forget most concepts taught during these sessions. The researchers recommended the use of interactive approaches such as simulations, hands-on workshops, and real-life case studies to make cybersecurity training more effective. [4]

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study used a mixed-method approach, combining both quantitative and qualitative techniques.

A well-structured questionnaire was prepared using Google Forms. The questions covered areas such as:

- internet usage habits
- awareness of cybersecurity
- password practices
- training received
- experience with cyberattacks
- suggestions from students

A total of 159 students responded from MCA, MBA, and Engineering courses.

The study used:

- percentage analysis
- frequency counts
- cross-sectional analysis
- simple comparisons (UG vs PG, daily users vs occasional users)

The goal was to identify patterns and understand the overall behavior of students.

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